

# Getting Started — VSO & First Steps

The smartest first move as a veteran is getting free, expert help and gathering your records. Below is how to start strong. Tick the box once you've done each one.

## ⚠ BEFORE YOU START

A free accredited VSO is your single best resource — they know the system, file claims at no cost, and dramatically improve your odds. Don't go it alone, and never pay for claim help.

## 1 Get Your Free Representative

Accredited help that costs nothing and works for you.

### ☐ Find an Accredited VSO

Officers from groups like the American Legion, DAV, and VFW file your claims for free.

→ [www.va.gov/get-help-from-accredited-representative](http://www.va.gov/get-help-from-accredited-representative)

### ☐ VA Hotline

Call the VA directly with any benefits question.

→ [www.va.gov](http://www.va.gov) 1-800-827-1000

## 2 Set Up Your Accounts

Get digital access to your benefits and records.

### ☐ Create a VA.gov Account

Manage claims, messages, prescriptions, and records online.

→ [www.va.gov](http://www.va.gov)

### ☐ Get Your DD-214 & Records

Your discharge papers prove eligibility. Request them free from the National Archives.

→ [www.archives.gov/veterans/military-service-records](http://www.archives.gov/veterans/military-service-records)

## 3 Understand Discharge & Eligibility

Your discharge status affects benefits — and can sometimes be upgraded.

### ☐ Check & Upgrade Your Discharge

A less-than-honorable discharge may still qualify, or be upgradable. Free help is available.

→ [www.va.gov/discharge-upgrade-instructions](http://www.va.gov/discharge-upgrade-instructions)

## 4 Protect Your Effective Date

One quick step preserves your back pay.

### ☐ File an Intent to File

Filing this on VA.gov locks in an earlier start date for benefits while you prepare your claim.

→ [www.va.gov/disability/how-to-file-claim](http://www.va.gov/disability/how-to-file-claim)

**⚠ WATCH OUT FOR**

Avoid for-profit “claim consultants” that charge fees or a percentage of your back pay — accredited VSOs do the same work free. Charging upfront for VA claim prep is against federal rules.

**★ A TIP THAT HELPS**

Gather your DD-214 and any medical records before your VSO appointment — the more evidence you bring, the faster and stronger your claim. File an intent to file the same day.

**NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?**

**Need help where you live?**

This guide covers national first steps. For your nearest VSO and records help, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area.

**MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID**

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